

BeThere

Taking the pain out of
friend group meetups

DRP02 - Nelson Gong, Noah Seymour, Lukas Trakimas, James Hughff

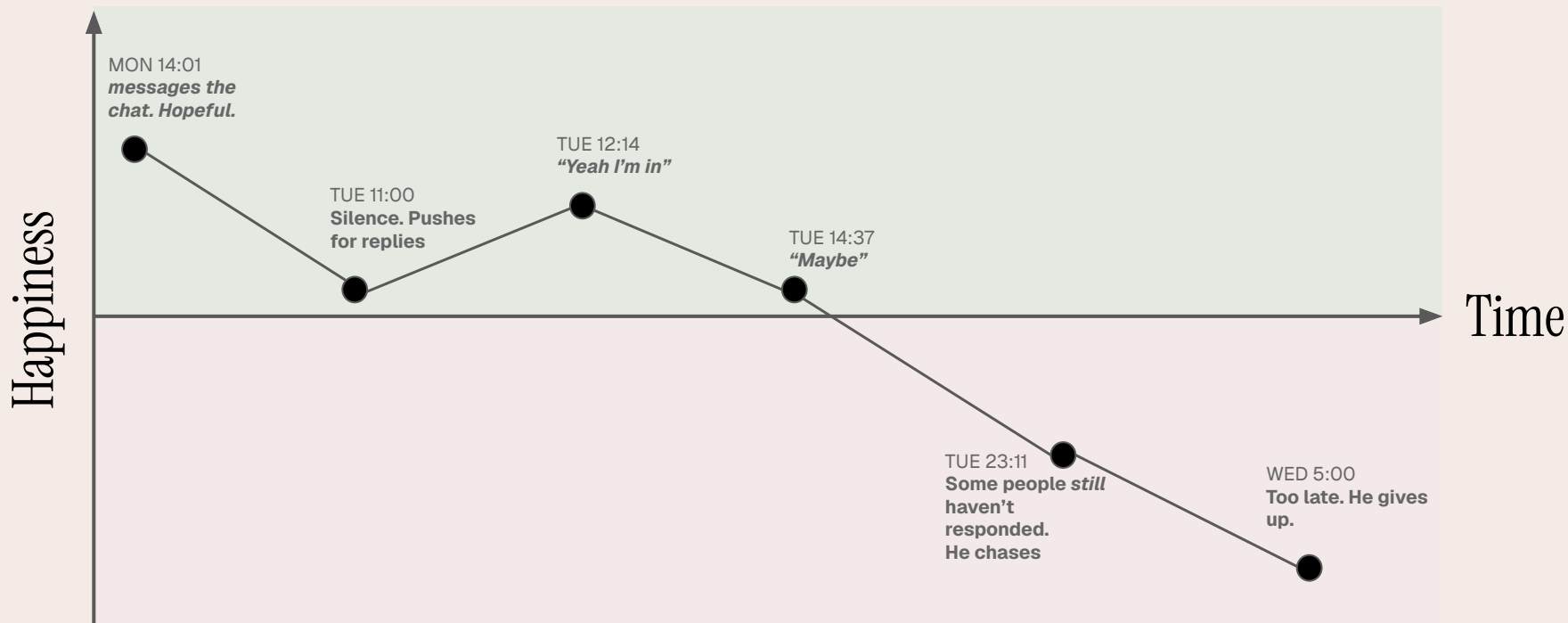
Vasanth

- Age 21
- Studies Law at St. Andrews
- Enjoys playing volleyball and board games
- Loves to cook for his friends
- Extroverted and reliable

The **organiser**.



Vasanth's Christmas break, mapped as he felt it.



Vasanth loves to meet his friends, but organising is difficult and chasing replies from group members is frustrating

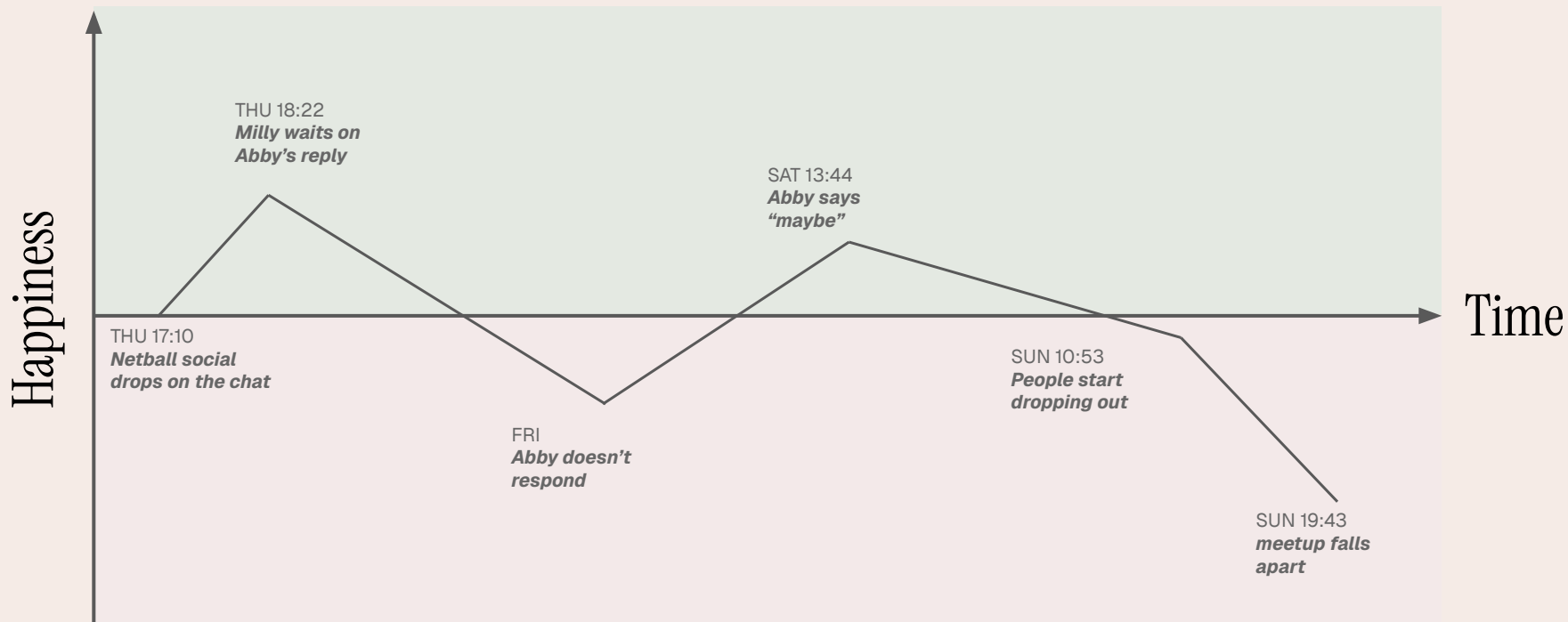
Milly

- Age 19
- Studies English Literature at St. Andrews
- Likes to play cello and read
- Recently joined her university's netball society
- Shy and introverted

The passive participant



Milly's netball social, mapped as she felt it.



Milly would love to engage with her netball society's socials more, but she is hesitant because she wants to be sure her friends are going too

To better understand this problem, we interviewed university students about their social lives.

“If I drummed up the plan, and it's taken considerable time, looking at logistics, pricing, whether everyone's okay with it, and then it falls through after all of that, that's quite frustrating.”

Eddie, 21, the *organiser*
3rd year Psychology at Goldsmiths





“As days went past, [the meetup] got more drawn out, second thoughts crept in, and more and more people ended up pulling out.”

Chloe, 19, the *passive participant*
2nd Year International Relations at King's College

*“If [I’m meeting] a friend of a friend,
my attendance is conditional on my
friend being there. I’ll wait for them to
respond first, then decide.”*

Luca, 20, the passive participant
BioChem at Oxford



Two key stakeholder groups.

1. SUGGESTORS

One sided and exhausting. *Awkward*
to push for replies.

2. PARTICIPANTS

Uncertainty *compounds* uncertainty.
Some people's participation is
contingent on others.

50%+

of our 47 survey respondents said **over a third** of meet-ups never made it out of the chat.

60%

said the meet-up time gets moved **half the time or more.**

87%

send a **maybe** or **delay** their response to a plan they are unsure about

a decade ago

7%

today

22%

of young people have one or no close friends

25%+

of lonely young people have sought therapy

*"How might we reduce **hesitancy** in undergraduate friend groups when planning to meet up so that groups go from frustrating '**maybe**' responses to a clear **consensus**?"*

User Story

As a social member of my friend group
who tends to organise things
I want to be able to easily suggest
meetups to my friends
So that I can see my friends more without
the frustration of chasing responses



Suggest a meet

GROUP

Lithuanian Study GroupClimbing Group

TITLE

Bouldering

LOCATION

Vauxwall East

DATE

2026-06-10

TIME

14:00

Create

“I could see this app being used to just check for people’s availability, like sending out this vague idea of ‘I want to meetup’ and seeing what everyone wants to do”

20:05

Suggest a meet

LOCATION optional

TenPin Bexleyheath

NOTES optional

Come at 6, we'll eat around 8

WHEN

FlexibleFixed

Offer a time or two; people react and it locks at a deadline.

Tomorrow eveThis SatSat eve

Next week

Thu, Jun 410:15 PM

+ Add a time

LOCKS IN

Locks Wed 3 Jun, 22:15
the evening before - best-supported time wins

Change

Float it

Add a title to continue

20:08

The Boys

LOCKS IN

11h 25m
best-supported time wins

Dancing

Which of these work?

Tap the times you can make - private to you.

Wed 3 Jun, 19:00

Sat 6 Jun, 13:00

+ Add a time

I can't make it
you won't be asked again - tap a time to rejoin

Force lock now (dev)

“Having a set time for the meetup seems quite restrictive, it would be nice to have some way to agree on a time within the group”

New meetup

HOW PINNED DOWN IS THIS?

Float it

Just an idea - drop it anonymously and let the group shape it.

Rough plan

You know what, not exactly when. Offer a few times; it locks itself.

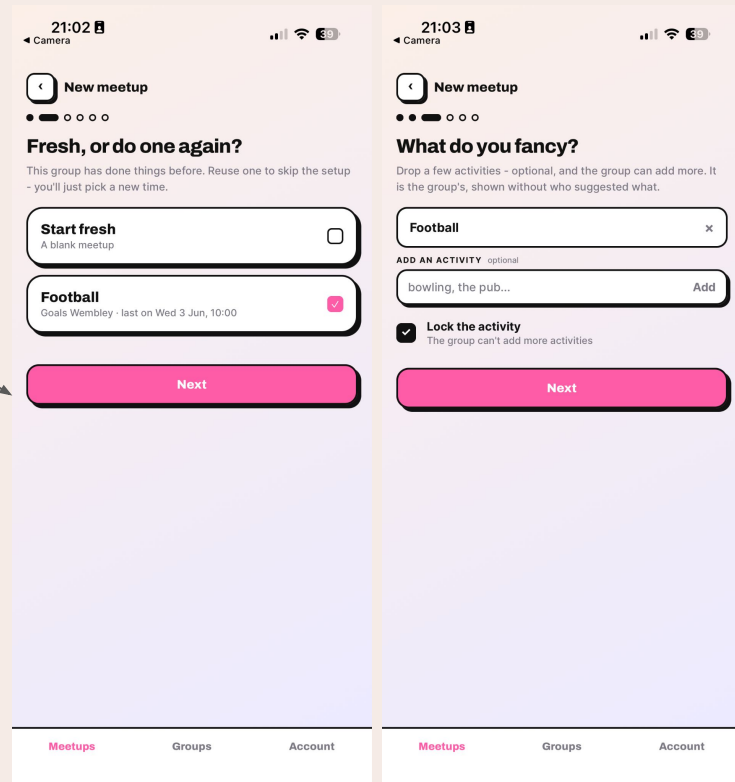
It's set

Fixed time and place. It's on - who's in?

“It’s not immediately obvious why there’s a flexible and fixed options for times. ”



“These options are quite confusing, I don’t really understand when you would ever use the rough plan option”



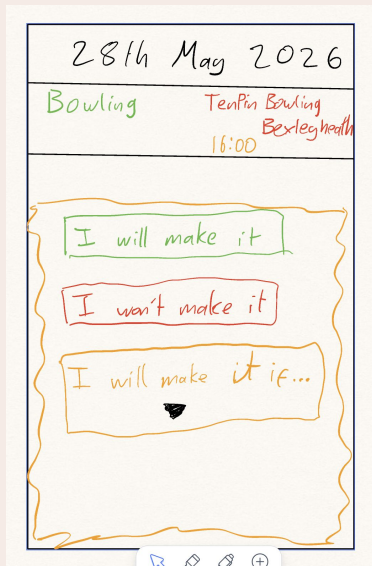
User Story

As a new and introverted member of a friend group

I want to only attend social events if I already know people going

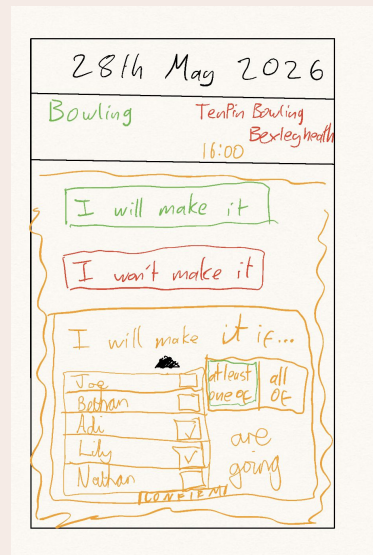
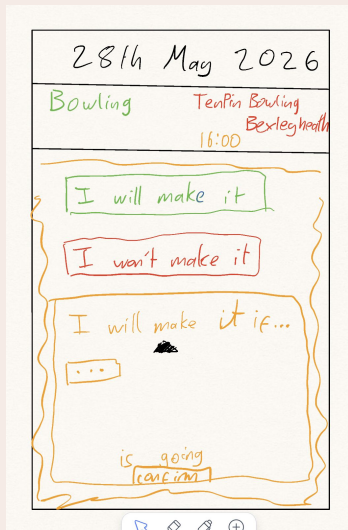
So that I feel comfortable





“It’s either I’ll go if one person goes or if like a group of people go. I don’t think I’d need something this complex”

“There’s gotta be an and-or type thing with the ifs. If you’re doing those checkboxes does that mean I’ll go if Adi and Lily are going or if either of them are going”



“These two options are definitely the things I’ll be thinking about if it were a meeting where I’d conditionally go”

28th May 2026

Bowling TenPin Bowling
Bextlegheadth
16:00

I will make it

I won't make it

I will make it if...

Change time to

These people make it ☐

Other condition

28th May 2026

Bowling TenPin Bowling
Bextlegheadth
16:00

I will make it

I won't make it

I will make it if...

...

is going
cancelling

28th May 2026

Bowling TenPin Bowling
Bextlegheadth
16:00

I will make it

I won't make it

I will make it if...

Joe	☐	at least	all
Bobban	☐	one of	of
Adi	☒		
Lily	☒		
Nathan	☒		

are going

16:00

28th May 2026

Bowling TenPin Bowling
Bexleyheath
16:00

I will make it

I won't make it

I will make it if...

Joe	☐
Bobhan	☐
Adi	☒
Lily	☒
Nathan	☐

are
going

Confirm

28th May 2026

Bowling TenPin Bowling
Bexleyheath
16:00

I will make it

I won't make it

I will make it if...

...

is going
confirm

28th May 2026

Bowling TenPin Bowling
Bexleyheath
16:00

I will make it

I won't make it

I will make it if...

Joe	☐
Bobhan	☐
Adi	☒
Lily	☒
Nathan	☐

at least
one of

are
going

confirm

28th May 2026

Bowling TenPin Bowling
Bexleyheath
16:00

I will make it

I won't make it

I will make it if...

Joe	☐
Bethan	☐
Adi	☒
Lily	☒
Nathan	☐

are
going

Confirm

28th May 2026

Bowling TenPin Bowling
Bexleyheath
16:00

I will make it

I won't make it

I will make it if...

☒	
Joe	Adi
Lily	Nathan
Bethan	

are going

28th May 2026

Bowling TenPin Bowling
Bexleyheath
16:00

I will make it

I won't make it

I will make it if...

Joe	☐
Bethan	☐
Adi	☒
Lily	☒
Nathan	☐

at least
one of

are
going

100% CONFIRM

28th May 2026

Bowling TenPin Bowling
Bexleyheath
16:00

I will make it

I won't make it

I will make it if...

Joe	☐
Bobhan	☐
Adi	☒
Lily	☒
Nathan	☐

are
going

Confirm

28th May 2026

Bowling TenPin Bowling
Bexleyheath
16:00

I will make it

I won't make it

I will make it if...



are going
I confirm

28th May 2026

Bowling TenPin Bowling
Bexleyheath
16:00

I will make it

I won't make it

I will make it if...

Joe	☐	at least	all
Bobhan	☐	one of	of
Adi	☒		
Lily	☒		
Nathan	☐		

are
going

I confirm

28th May 2026

Bowling TenPin Bowling
Bexleyheath
16:00

I will make it

I won't make it

I will make it if...

Jag	☐
Bethan	☐
Adi	☒
Lily	☒
Nathan	☐

are
going

Confirm

28th May 2026

Bowling TenPin Bowling
Bexleyheath
16:00

I will make it

I won't make it

I will make it if...

☒ Lily	☐ Adi
Bethan	Nathan

are going

28th May 2026

Bowling TenPin Bowling
Bexleyheath
16:00

I will make it

I won't make it

I will make it if...

Jag	☐
Bethan	☐
Adi	☒
Lily	☒
Nathan	☐

at least
one of

are
going

CONFIRM

28th May 2026

Bowling TenPin Bowling
Bexleyheath
16:00

I will make it

I won't make it

I will make it if...

Joe	☐
Bethan	☐
Adi	☒
Lily	☒
Nathan	☐

are
going

confirm

28th May 2026

Bowling TenPin Bowling
Bexleyheath
16:00

I will make it

I won't make it

I will make it if...

Joe AND Lily
OR

...

are going
confirm

28th May 2026

Bowling TenPin Bowling
Bexleyheath
16:00

I will make it

I won't make it

I will make it if...

Joe	☐
Bethan	☐
Adi	☒
Lily	☒
Nathan	☐

at least
one of

are
going

confirm

28th May 2026

Bowling TenPin Bowling
Bexleyheath
16:00

I will make it

I won't make it

I will make it if...

Joe	☐
Bethan	☐
Adi	☒
Lily	☒
Nathan	☐

are
going

Confirm

28th May 2026

Bowling TenPin Bowling
Bexleyheath
16:00

I will make it

I won't make it

I will make it if...

☐	
Bethan	Adi
Nathan	

are going

28th May 2026

Bowling TenPin Bowling
Bexleyheath
16:00

I will make it

I won't make it

I will make it if...

Joe	☐
Bethan	☐
Adi	☒
Lily	☒
Nathan	☐

at least
one of

are
going

100% TERNI

28th May 2026

Bowling TenPin Bowling
Bexleyheath
16:00

I will make it

I won't make it

I will make it if...

Joe	☐
Bobhan	☐
Adi	☒
Lily	☒
Nathan	☐

are
going

confirm

28th May 2026

Bowling TenPin Bowling
Bexleyheath
16:00

I will make it

I won't make it

I will make it if...

Joe	AND	Lily
OR		
Nathan	OR	...
OR		

are going
confirm

28th May 2026

Bowling TenPin Bowling
Bexleyheath
16:00

I will make it

I won't make it

I will make it if...

Joe	☐
Bobhan	☐
Adi	☒
Lily	☒
Nathan	☐

at least
one of

are
going

confirm

User Story

As someone wanting to organise a meetup for my friends

I don't want to have to convince people to download a new app

So that I can save time and avoid frustration



Gamer boys

GROUP NAME

Gamer boys

MEMBERS (1)

L

Lukas Trakimas

x

Invite to group

MY MEETUPS

MY GROUPS

Gamer boys

GROUP NAME

Gamer boys

MEMBERS (1)

L

Lukas Trakimas

x

Invite to group

Invite to group

Anyone with the code can join.

JOIN CODE

KT4D-4AHH

Copy

INVITE LINK

https://bethere-dev.vercel.app/join/KT4D4AHH

Copy

Share invite

Meetup

VOTING CLOSES

5 days left

Top pick wins

The Boys

Edit

What

+ add an activity

When

+ add a time

☐ Can't make it

Tap anything above to rejoin

No names, just the group.

Share this meetup

Anyone with the link can join and respond.

INVITE LINK

https://bethere-dev.vercel.app/m/e_d63c1c81-e2d5-4ddd-a1

Copy

Share invite

You're invited

TB

The Boys

Help pick a time

Join The Boys & respond

Continue as test user

No app to download.



User Story

As a student in numerous friend groups
I want to suggest meetups bringing together
several groups of people and I want to allow
friends to bring along their friends
So that I can invite people I don't know who
would improve the event.



Meetup

VOTING CLOSES

5 days left

Top pick wins

The Boys

Edit

The Boys

What

+ add an activity

When

+ add a time

☐ Can't make it

Tap anything above to rejoin

No names, just the group.

Share this meetup

Anyone with the link can join and respond.

INVITE LINK

https://bethere-dev.vercel.app/m/e_d63c1c81-e2d5-4ddd-at

Copy

Share invite

You're invited

TB

The Boys

Help pick a time

Join The Boys & respond

Continue as test user

No app to download.

“Going to a group event is a lot about the chemistry between the group right. And if someone was there I didn’t really know it might ruin that.”



New meetup

Who's it for?

Pick one or more groups - everyone's invited.

The Boys

Climbing Group

Glitter Natters

Church Group

High School Reunion

+ New group

☒ Open to +1s

Anyone with the meetup link can join

☐ Lock this choice

Otherwise any group member can change it later

Next

MY MEETUPS

MY GROUPS

lunch

VOTING CLOSES

17 hours left

Top pick wins

lunch

Edit

The Boys

Who's invited

2 people

1 new

What

☐ lunch

0

+ add an activity

When

☐ Sat 13 Jun, 15:23

0

☐ Can't make it

Tap anything above to rejoin

No names, just the group.

Who's invited

2 people

☒ Open to +1s

Anyone with the meetup link can join

The Boys

L

Leixin Gong

+1s

L

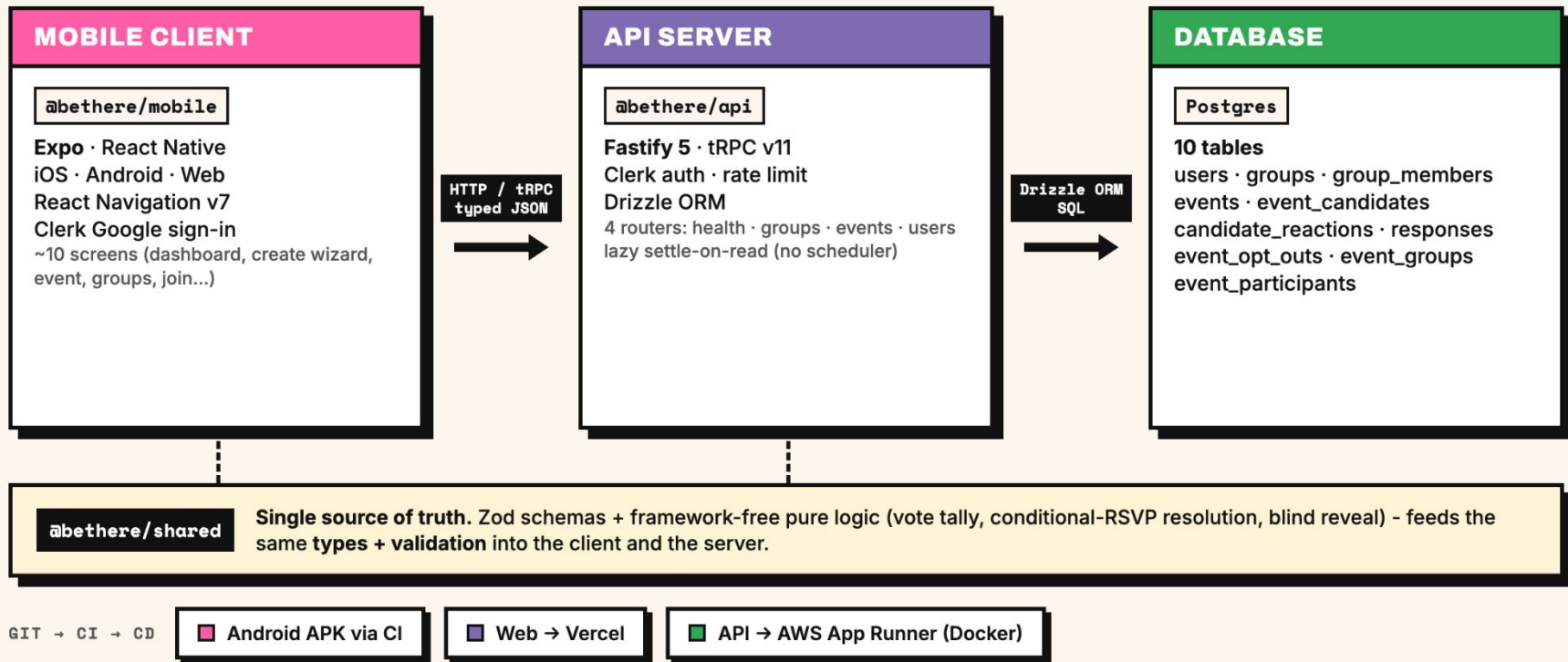
Lukas Trakimas

via Leixin Gong

1 new

Implementation

System Architecture



Why this **stack**

TypeScript + pnpm monorepo

One language across client, server, and shared logic. Refactors are **type-checked end to end**.

tRPC v11 + Zod

A **fully type-safe API** with zero hand-written types or codegen. One schema validates server input and types the client.

Expo / React Native

One codebase ships to **iOS, Android, and web** - so we could test with real users on whatever device they already had.

Fastify 5

A lightweight, fast Node server - a thin, low-overhead host for the tRPC layer.

Postgres + Drizzle ORM

Groups, votes, and RSVPs are inherently relational, so the database gives us **integrity for free**, with typed SQL.

Clerk

Managed auth with **real Google OAuth** - we don't roll our own identity or security.

Git → GitHub Actions CI/CD

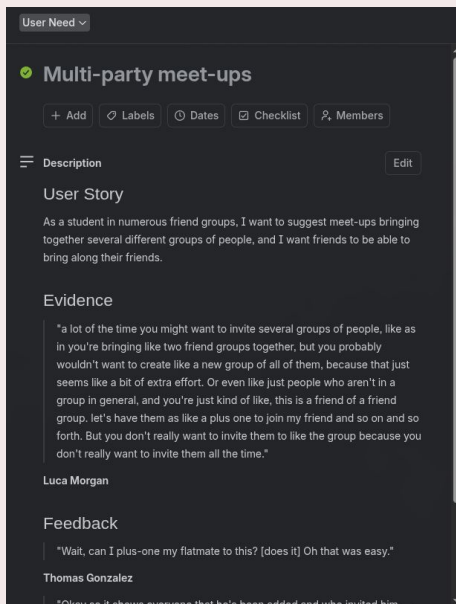
Lint, typecheck, and tests run on **every change**, with continuous deployment to AWS App Runner (API) and Vercel (web).

What Went Well

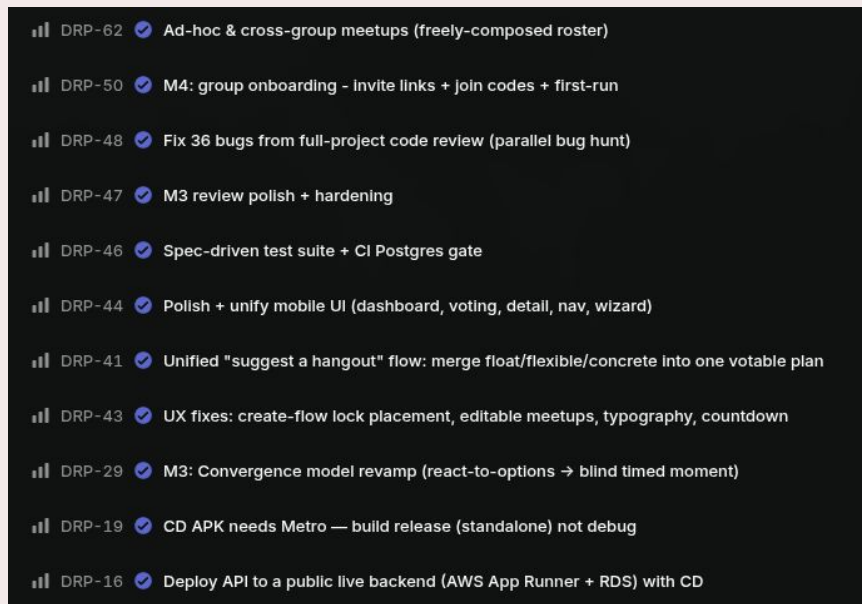
Continuous feedback from **new** and **recurring** users gave us diverse insights into how the problem is actually solved.

Letting users plan **real** meetups with their friends using BeThere helped identify the pain points of the app.

Agile Development



Trello for mapping user needs.



Linear for engineering issues.

What We Would Do
Differently

Testing : A stronger test suite with wider code coverage would've prevented bugs from recurring.

Sprint planning: Earlier iterations were too feature-focused, user stories were an afterthought.

Impact

User Impacts and Benefits

Vasanth:

- Goes out with his friends regularly, despite his busy schedule.
- Feels less lonely.

Milly:

- Is more comfortable with meeting new people.
- Has begun suggesting meetups of her own.



Wider Impacts

University counselling
services.

NHS mental health
provision.

University
societies.

Local venues.

Looking Ahead

Milly's availability may change
after confirming she'll **BeThere** .

People who will go if Milly goes want to be
notified she might not make it.

Plus-ones are still an awkward problem.

Vasanth may welcome plus-ones to his meetup, but there are some people he would prefer not to see there.

Meetup logistics are full of nuance,
we cannot capture every case.

An in-app chat dedicated to the meetup,
available after confirmation, would let the
group settle the details.